

HELD THE LINE

written by  
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First Draft

FADE IN:

**INT. KOVACH HOUSE -- LIVING ROOM -- VISALIA, CALIFORNIA -- DAY**

Overexposed. Afternoon light through sheer curtains that have hung there for forty years, bleaching everything toward white.

Folding chairs, borrowed from a church, in loose rows nobody straightened after. Paper plates in a trash bag that leans against the couch. On every surface: casserole dishes with masking-tape names on the lids. FERGUSON. NAKAMURA. THE PRICE FAMILY.

The funeral is over. This is the after.

WYATT KOVACH, 20, sits on a folding chair in a dress shirt that fit him two years ago, sleeves rolled because the buttons at the wrist are gone. He is not crying. He has the stillness of someone who has checked, privately, several times today, whether he is about to cry, and gotten no answer either way.

His phone is in his hand, face down against his thigh. It buzzes. He doesn't turn it over. It buzzes again. He doesn't turn it over. This costs him something. We can see it costing him something.

Around him, at the margins, the machinery of death: an UNCLE wrapping the good chairs in moving blankets. A NEIGHBOR, 70s, washing dishes that are not hers in a kitchen that is about to stop being anyone's.

DENISE (O.S.)

Wyatt.

DENISE KOVACH, 52, his mother, in the doorway with a legal pad. Grieving the way some people grieve: as a project manager. There is a list on the pad. There are checkmarks on the list.

DENISE (CONT'D)

The dumpster comes Thursday. I need the garage and the spare room gone through before Thursday. Keep, donate, trash. Three piles.

WYATT

Which spare room?

DENISE

Dad's.

A small silence. That word did something in the room, faintly, like a pipe knocking in a wall.

WYATT

Nobody's been in there since --

DENISE

Since Grandpa died. I know.  
That's why it's on the list.

(beat; softer, which  
for her means two  
degrees)

Mom kept it exactly how it was.  
Eleven years. Heat that room  
summer and winter for a man who  
wasn't in it.

(back to the pad)

Three piles, Wyatt.

She's gone. Wyatt looks at the phone against his thigh.  
Turns it over, finally.

INSERT -- PHONE: a group chat he is no longer in, visible only as a notification from someone screenshotting it TO him, which is worse. We don't read all of it. We catch: "...still can't believe wyatt of all people..." and a number: 43 comments.

He puts the phone face down on the empty folding chair beside him, like setting down something hot.

**INT. KOVACH HOUSE -- HALLWAY -- DAY**

Wyatt walks the hallway. The walls are a museum nobody curated: school photos of Denise with 1980s bangs. A watercolor of a lighthouse. And near the end, small, frameless, tucked at eye level where you'd only see it if you lived here:

A PHOTOGRAPH. Black and white. A YOUNG MAN, 19 or 20, in Marine dress uniform, unsmiling. Not solemn -- unsmiling, which is different. His eyes are looking slightly past the camera, at something over the photographer's shoulder, and whatever it is, he does not like it.

Wyatt stops. Looks at it the way you look at a word you've read a thousand times that suddenly looks misspelled.

WYATT  
(calling back down the  
hall)  
Ma. Who's this by the bathroom?

DENISE (O.S.)  
(from another room;  
distracted)  
That's Grandpa, honey.

Wyatt looks again. The young man in the photo is younger than he is.

**INT. KOVACH HOUSE -- GRANDPA'S SPARE ROOM -- DAY**

The door sticks, then gives. Stale, held air -- eleven years of it.

A single bed, made, with hospital corners. A workbench under the window, tools shadow-boarded on pegboard, every outline filled -- a man who fixed things with his hands and put them back. A recliner facing not the window but the door. A TV old enough to have a dial, unplugged, the cord coiled and tied.

It is the room of a man who was quiet, and the quiet is still in here, banked like coals.

Wyatt stands in the doorway a moment. Then he starts, because there's a list and a dumpster and a Thursday.

**MONTAGE -- THE GRUNT WORK OF DEATH:**

-- Flannel shirts into the DONATE pile, still on their hangers, shoulders holding a shape.

-- A coffee can of washers and screws, sorted by size. Wyatt hesitates over which pile a lifetime of sorted washers belongs in. TRASH. It lands like a verdict.

-- A drawer: reading glasses, a watch that stopped, a water district retirement plaque, 34 YEARS. Every object gets three seconds and a pile.

-- Wyatt working faster now, numb finding a rhythm, phone forgotten --

-- and then, in the closet, behind a wall of blankets folded to regulation, on the floor, under a canvas tarp:

A FOOTLOCKER.

Olive drab gone gray-green. Steel corners rust-freckled. Stenciled on the lid, faded to a whisper but legible:

R. J. KOVACH -- D-1-7 -- USMC

A padlock, small and old, hangs from the hasp. Wyatt pulls it. Stiff. Holding.

WYATT  
(quietly; to the room)  
Okay.

He looks at the shadow-boarded pegboard. Every tool in its outline. He takes down the bolt cutters.

Beat. He looks at the lock. At the stenciled name. Puts the bolt cutters BACK in their outline.

And instead: the coffee can of sorted washers -- and beneath it, a smaller can, KEYS, each tagged in pencil. He walks his fingers through them. Little paper tags: TRUCK. SIDE GATE. E's SHED.

And one, at the bottom, older than the rest, on a wire loop, tag soft as cloth. The pencil faded almost to nothing. He tilts it to the window light.

The tag reads: "NO."

Wyatt looks at that for a long moment. A key, kept for seventy years, labeled NO. Kept anyway.

He fits it to the padlock. It turns like it was oiled last week -- and knowing this room, it was.

The hasp swings. Wyatt lifts the lid. The hinges make the sound old hinges make, and the smell comes up at him -- canvas, gun oil, paper, and under it something faint and green and wrong, like the ghost of wet rot --

INSIDE THE FOOTLOCKER:

A folded uniform, moth-holed. A flat bronze star on a ribbon gone colorless. Dog tags on a chain, two of them, KOVACH R J. A yellowed envelope thick with papers. A photograph of six young men shirtless in front of a tent, arms slung, five of them laughing. A rosary with a decade of beads missing, the wire ends twisted shut by hand, a repair. And a pair of GLASSES, army-issue round frames, one lens spider-cracked, both temples gone -- just the front of a pair of glasses, kept for seventy years.

Wyatt kneels there. Picks up the dog tags first, because they're on top. The chain pours into his palm, cool, heavier than it looks.

He turns the tag to read it. His thumb moves over the stamped letters --

KOVACH R J --

-- and the air conditioner hum of the house, the distant clink of the neighbor's dishwashing, all of it --

CUTS OUT.

Hard cut. No dissolve. No sound bridge. Like a breaker thrown:

**EXT. LUNGA PERIMETER -- GUADALCANAL -- DUSK -- OCTOBER 24, 1942**

RAIN. Not movie rain -- a gray roaring weight, jungle rain, and under it the ridge: a hogback of mud and kunai grass south of an airfield, and dug into it, a line of fighting holes and two water-cooled machine guns under dripping camouflage.

Handheld. Ugly. Close. The light is dying.

RAYMOND "RAY" KOVACH, 19 -- the unsmiling boy from the hallway photo, but alive, moving, mud to the ears -- lies behind a Browning M1917, checking the water jacket, checking the traverse, checking it again, because checking is the only thing his hands are allowed to want.

Around him, his section: BILLIE JOE CRUMPTON, 18, Alabama, feeding belt into the tray with fingers pruned white by rain. GAETANO "GUY" RUSSO, 21, Brooklyn, on the second gun ten yards down. A CORPORAL, PYNE, 24, who has been nineteen days on this island and looks fifty.

Nobody is talking. The rain is talking.

Then, moving down the line behind them, low, fast, checking each hole like a foreman walking a pour: a MANILA GYSGT, sleeves rolled over forearms like bridge cable, a .45 on his hip -- GUNNERY SERGEANT JOHN BASILONE, 25. He does not look like a legend. He looks like a man doing inventory.

He drops beside Ray's gun. Doesn't look at Ray. Looks at the gun.

BASILONE  
 Headspace.

RAY  
 Set it twice, Gunny.

BASILONE  
 (already lifting the  
 cover, checking it  
 himself; not an insult,  
 a religion)  
 Set it three times.

He works the bolt. Listens to it the way a man listens to  
 an engine. Closes the cover. Now -- only now -- he looks  
 at Ray. One second. Rain running off both their helmets.

BASILONE (CONT'D)  
 Where you from?

RAY  
 Johnstown. Pennsylvania.

BASILONE  
 (a grunt; almost a  
 smile; not quite)  
 Steel.  
 (rising, moving to the  
 next hole, already  
 gone)  
 Gun stays up, Pennsylvania.

That's it. That's the whole conversation. Ray watches him  
 move down the line, a dark shape checking dark shapes, and  
 something in Ray's face banks itself down and settles in  
 behind the gun.

CRUMPTON  
 (low; feeding belt; to  
 Ray)  
 Colonel put us on this ridge  
 'cause the wire's thin here.

RAY  
 (eyes forward, into the  
 treeline, into the  
 rain, where the light  
 is almost gone now)  
 Wire's thin everywhere.

Out in that treeline: nothing. Rain. Dark coming up out of  
 the ground like water rising.

And then, far off, under the rain -- a sound. Not gunfire. Voices. Thousands of them, distant, rhythmic, coming through the jungle like weather.

Crumpton stops feeding the belt.

CRUMPTON  
...The hell is that.

PYNE (O.S.)  
(down the line; flat)  
That's them talking themselves  
into it.

Ray settles his shoulder into the stock. Rain on the water jacket. Rain on his hands. The voices out there, rising --

-- and HARD CUT:

**INT. KOVACH HOUSE -- GRANDPA'S SPARE ROOM -- DAY**

Silence. The air conditioner hum. Overexposed daylight.

Wyatt on his knees at the footlocker, dog tags in his fist, breathing like he came up from underwater. Maybe four seconds have passed in this room.

From down the hall, ordinary as anything:

DENISE (O.S.)  
Wyatt? Keep, donate, or trash on  
the bedding?

Wyatt looks at the tags in his hand. At the open locker. At the yellowed envelope, thick with papers, waiting.

WYATT  
(calling back; voice  
almost level)  
Keep.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

**INT. KOVACH HOUSE -- GRANDPA'S SPARE ROOM -- LATER**

The three piles have stopped growing. The list has stopped mattering. Wyatt sits on the floor with his back against the bed, the footlocker open in front of him like a mouth, and the yellowed envelope in his lap.



He unwinds the string clasp. Slides the papers out with two fingers, careful, the way you'd handle something that might still be loaded.

ON THE PAPERS, as he sorts them on the carpet:

-- A DISCHARGE. "KOVACH, RAYMOND JOHN. Corporal. Honorable." Enlisted January 1942. Johnstown, Pennsylvania. Age at enlistment: 18.

-- A UNIT COMMENDATION, typed on onionskin, the letters punched deep by a heavy hand: "...for extraordinary heroism while serving with the First Battalion, Seventh Marines, First Marine Division, during action against enemy Japanese forces at the Lunga Area, Guadalcanal, Solomon Islands, on the night of 24-25 October 1942. When the sections' positions were subjected to repeated assaults by a numerically superior enemy force, Corporal Kovach maintained accurate and effective fire..."

Wyatt reads. His lips move slightly on "numerically superior."

-- A NAVY CROSS CITATION -- not Ray's. A carbon copy, third or fourth generation, nearly gray: "BASILONE, JOHN, Gunnery Sergeant..." Someone -- Ray -- has kept another man's citation for seventy years. In the margin, in pencil, in a workingman's careful print, one annotation, next to the printed words "contributed materially to the defeat":

"3 of us left. He carried the ammo. Nobody carried us."

-- The PHOTOGRAPH: six young men, shirtless, in front of a tent. Wyatt turns it over. On the back, in the same pencil: "Pyne. Crumpton. Russo. Me. Beck. Ostrowski." And under the names, added later, a different pencil, blunter: five small crosses. And one name -- "Me" -- without one.

Wyatt looks at that for a long time. Six names. Five crosses. Do the math and it doesn't work -- three walked off that ridge. The papers don't explain. The crosses were added over years. The war didn't stop collecting when the shooting did.

-- And last, at the bottom of the envelope: a LETTER. Unsent. No envelope of its own. Ruled paper, folded in thirds so long ago the folds have gone to fabric. Dated -- Wyatt checks twice -- 1978. Thirty-six years after.

INSERT -- THE LETTER, Ray's careful print, the letters small and even like machine work:

"Eleanor. You asked me again Sunday and I got up from the table and I want to tell you why I get up from the table. In October of 1942 I was on a ridge above an airfield with"

That's it. Mid-sentence. The pen didn't even finish the line. Below it, half an inch down, started again, days or years later, the print slightly different:

"Eleanor. It is not that I don't"

And that's it. Twice. Two runs at it, thirty-six years on, and the wire's thin everywhere.

Wyatt holds the letter. His thumb rests on the word "Eleanor" -- his grandmother's name, three days buried --

-- and the room CUTS OUT:

**EXT. THE RIDGE -- LUNGA PERIMETER -- NIGHT -- OCTOBER 24, 1942**

FULL DARK and the world is ending.

Muzzle flashes strobe the rain. Mortars walk somewhere behind the line, each impact a fist through the chest of the sound mix. And from the treeline, out of the dark, the voices are no longer distant -- they are a WALL, a screamed syllable rolling up the slope with three thousand men behind it.

RAY'S GUN is firing. Long disciplined bursts, traverse and search, the water jacket steaming in the rain. Crumpton feeds. The belt races. Everything is rain, muzzle light, mud, and noise so total it becomes a kind of silence.

Shapes in the wire now. Close. A GRENADE arcs in -- Ray sees it land in the mud two holes down, sees the flash, doesn't hear it as separate from everything --

PYNE (O.S.)  
(screaming down the  
line)

GUN TWO! GUN TWO'S QUIET! RUSSO!

Ray, firing, risks one look right. Where Russo's gun should be flashing: darkness. A hole in the line's noise, and through that hole, the dark starts POURING.

CRUMPTON  
 (feeding; voice  
 cracking; a kid)  
 They're inside it, Ray, they're  
 inside the wire --

RAY  
 (not stopping; traverse  
 and search; the  
 checking-hands voice,  
 flat as pipe)  
 Feed the gun.

CRUMPTON  
 Ray --

RAY  
 FEED THE GUN.

LATER -- the rain slacking, then regathering. The gun's  
 water jacket steams. Crumpton has stopped flinching at the  
 mortars, which is not improvement.

CRUMPTON (CONT'D)  
 (feeding; hollow; to  
 nobody)  
 My daddy says a man can get used  
 to anything. He worked the mill  
 forty years.  
 (beat; the belt runs)  
 He never said how fast, though.  
 That's the part.  
 (beat)  
 It's fast, Ray. That's the part  
 nobody says. It's one night.

RAY  
 (traverse; search; not  
 unkind)  
 Watch your feed.

LATER STILL -- a lull long enough to be worse than the  
 noise. Ray pours the last of a canteen into the gun's  
 jacket, not his mouth. Down the line, someone is saying  
 the Act of Contrition, fast, conversational, like a man  
 reading a parts list.

PYNE crawls up out of the dark, drops beside the pit. His  
 hands aren't right. He looks at them like borrowed tools.

PYNE

(quietly; to Ray)

Beck's gone. Ostrowski's gone.

(beat)

It took me this long to come tell  
you because I couldn't remember  
which hole was yours. I dug half  
these holes with you Tuesday and  
I couldn't --

(he stops;

recalibrates; the voice

goes flat and

administrative, and

this, the film

understands, is how men

survive the night --

they become paperwork)

You got Crumpton. Russo's got

Ellis from Baker Company now.

Ammo discipline. Short bursts.

He's gone, down the line. Ray looks at Crumpton. Crumpton is looking at the treeline and his lips are moving and no sound is coming out and his hands are still feeding the belt, perfect, automatic, and Ray reaches over and puts one hand flat on the kid's shoulder -- one second, the Basilone gesture, already inherited, passed down the line like ammunition --

-- and the treeline SCREAMS again, and the night resumes.

And then -- behind them, low, out of the dark, moving at a dead run bent under ninety pounds of Browning like a man carrying a roof beam through a burning house: BASILONE, gun on his shoulder, ammo hung off him, sprinting the two hundred yards of beaten ground toward Russo's silent position with rounds snapping past him the whole way.

Ray sees it in strobe: flash -- the Gunny running -- dark -- flash -- closer -- dark -- flash -- down into the dead gun's pit, and within seconds that hole in the line's noise is FIRING again, long and steady, the roof beam nailed back in.

No speech. Ray was never going to get a speech. What he gets, a minute or an hour later -- time has stopped being a number -- is Basilone appearing beside their hole out of nowhere, slapping a fresh belt can into the mud beside Crumpton, and putting his hand flat on the receiver of Ray's gun for one second, like checking a horse.

BASILONE  
 (over the noise; not  
 shouting; somehow  
 underneath the noise)  
 Still steel?

RAY  
 Still steel, Gunny.

BASILONE  
 (gone, already crawling  
 to the next hole)  
 Stay that way.

The dark comes up the slope again. The gun steams.  
 Crumpton is crying and feeding the belt at the same time  
 and his hands do not stop and neither does the belt, and  
 the rain comes down through all of it like the sky is  
 trying to put the whole island out --

HARD CUT:

**INT. KOVACH HOUSE -- SPARE ROOM -- DAY**

Silence like a slammed door. The overexposed curtains. The  
 AC hum.

Wyatt sits with the unsent letter in his hand. He becomes  
 aware that his own breathing is audible. He becomes aware  
 that his phone, across the room on the workbench, is  
 buzzing again -- and that for the last several minutes, it  
 has been buzzing into a world where he simply wasn't.

He looks at the phone. Doesn't get up.

He looks back at the letter. "It is not that I don't"

DENISE (O.S.)  
 (hallway; approaching)  
 It's six, I'm heading out, the  
 Fergusons want their dish back --

She stops in the doorway. Takes in the room: her son on  
 the floor, papers fanned around him, an open footlocker  
 she has never seen in her life in a room she grew up down  
 the hall from.

DENISE (CONT'D)  
 What's all this?

Wyatt looks up at her. And here is his first real choice  
 in the film, and we watch him make it:

WYATT  
 (gathering the papers,  
 evening the stack,  
 casual)  
 Grandpa's service stuff.  
 Discharge papers.  
 (beat)  
 I'll go through it. It's mostly  
 moth balls.

DENISE  
 (a beat; the pull of  
 the list winning out  
 over the pull of the  
 room)  
 Well -- keep pile. Obviously.  
 (turning; then, from  
 the hall, not really a  
 question)  
 He never talked about any of  
 that, you know.

WYATT  
 (quietly; to the  
 papers)  
 Yeah. I'm getting that.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

**INT. KOVACH HOUSE -- KITCHEN -- NIGHT**

The house empty now except for him. One light on over the stove. Wyatt eats somebody's funeral casserole cold, standing up, the footlocker's papers spread on the kitchen table like a case file.

His phone lies at the table's far edge. Face up now. He's allowed it back. The screen lights: a text from a number he hasn't deleted but has un-named -- it just says the number. The message preview: "hey. saw you were at your grandmas funeral. i know things are weird but"

He watches the screen until it sleeps. Doesn't pick it up. Whatever "weird" is -- whatever happened, the pile-on, the thread, the forty-three comments -- the film keeps it where Wyatt keeps it: off to the edge of the table, face up, unanswered.

He pulls the group photo closer instead. Six names. Five crosses.

WYATT  
 (to the photo; barely  
 aloud)  
 Which one of you had the glasses?

He picks up the broken glasses from the footlocker -- the cracked lens, the missing temples -- turns them in the stove light. They're not Ray's. Ray's discharge lists vision 20/20.

He holds them up to the photo. Six shirtless boys. And there -- second from left, laughing, round frames catching the tent-light: OSTROWSKI.

Wyatt goes still. He is holding, he realizes, another man's glasses, carried home across the Pacific and kept oiled-lock safe for seventy years by a man who wouldn't talk at holidays.

His thumb, without him deciding it, moves across the cracked lens --

CUT TO:

**EXT. THE RIDGE -- NIGHT -- LATER -- OCTOBER 24-25, 1942**

The assault has broken and re-formed twice. The slope below the wire is a dark texture we do not light and do not examine, and the rain has finally begun to slack, which is worse -- you can hear more now.

IN THE GUN PIT: Ray, changing a scalding barrel with his bare hands because the asbestos mitt is somewhere in the mud and there is no time -- his palms SEAR, he makes a sound through his teeth and does not stop. Crumpton is bleeding from somewhere in the scalp, thin and dramatic the way scalp wounds are, working one-handed now, the other hand just -- wrong.

PYNE (O.S.)  
 (hoarse; ten yards of  
 dark away)  
 Kovach. Count.

RAY  
 Two up here. Gun's up.

PYNE (O.S.)  
 Russo?

Silence from Russo's pit. Then, small:

RUSSO (O.S.)  
Up. It's -- yeah. Up.

Nobody asks about Beck. Nobody asks about Ostrowski. The line has learned tonight not to ask questions the dark has already answered.

RAY  
(low, to Crumpton,  
wrapping a field  
dressing around his own  
burned palm with his  
teeth)  
Ammo.

CRUMPTON  
(checking; a bad pause)  
Two belts. And whatever's loose.

Ray looks at the two belts. At the treeline, where the voices are massing again, rebuilding the wall.

RAY  
(flat)  
Okay.

CRUMPTON  
Ray. Two belts.

RAY  
I heard you.

CRUMPTON  
The trail's cut. Nobody's coming  
up that trail.

And out of the dark behind the pit -- movement. Both of them spin -- rifle, pistol --

BASILONE, bareheaded now, soaked, mud to the collar. He drops a crate of belts in the mud -- then a second -- carried through cut-off, hostile ground, alone, by hand, because the trail was blocked and someone had to.

BASILONE  
(already turning to go  
back for more; the  
whole exchange in  
stride)  
Make it last.



RAY  
 (a beat; he can't help  
 it; nineteen years old)  
 Gunny -- the trail's cut --

BASILONE  
 (pausing one  
 half-second at the  
 pit's edge; looking  
 down at Ray; rain off  
 his chin; and this is  
 as close to a speech as  
 the record or this film  
 will allow him)  
 So's theirs.

Gone. Into the dark. Ray and Crumpton look at each other.  
 Crumpton starts to laugh -- a wrong, high sound -- and  
 cuts it off himself, and feeds the new belt into the tray  
 with his one good hand.

The voices come up the slope again.

RAY  
 (shoulder to the stock;  
 to the gun, or to  
 himself; the family  
 voice, the  
 fixing-things voice,  
 born right here)  
 All right. All right. All right.

The gun opens up --

HARD CUT:

**INT. KOVACH HOUSE -- KITCHEN -- NIGHT**

The refrigerator cycles on. Wyatt is standing at the  
 table, both palms flat on it, head down, the glasses in  
 front of him. His hands, we notice, are pressed on the  
 wood the way you press on something to make sure it's real  
 and room temperature.

He straightens. Looks at his phone, still face up, still  
 patient.

He picks it up -- and for one second we brace for the  
 doom-scroll -- but instead he opens the camera, and  
 photographs the papers, one by one, flat and careful,  
 evidence-style: discharge, commendation, citation with the  
 pencil margin, the photo of six, the letter that stops  
 twice.

Then he opens a browser. Types into the search bar, hunt-and-peck, the words hitting like the film's title card:

INSERT -- SEARCH BAR: "basilone henderson field how many survived"

The results load. Wyatt sits down slowly, still reading, in his dead grandfather's chair, and the stove light holds him there, one small lit man in a dark house, going down and down and down into it.

MATCH CUT TO:

**EXT. THE RIDGE -- PRE-DAWN -- OCTOBER 25, 1942**

One small lit stretch of ridge in a dark island. Same composition. Different war.

The rain has stopped. Fog stands in the low ground like floodwater. And the assaults keep coming -- not waves anymore, floes -- groups of the enemy inside the wire now, close, and the fight has stopped being about the gun.

Because the gun is JAMMED. Ray, on his knees, cover up, tearing at a ruptured cartridge with burned fingers, no extractor tool, the barrel glowing a dull animal red in the dark and hissing where the fog touches it. His hands are past pain into something administrative.

RAY  
(to the gun; steady; a  
man talking a child  
through a nosebleed)  
Come on. Come on now. Come on --

A shape comes over the parapet.

What happens next is FAST and TERRIBLE and NOT choreography: Crumpton swings an empty belt can, Ray gets the .45 up off the mud, it's three seconds of animal chaos in the dark, and then it's over, and neither of them looks at what it left, and Ray goes BACK TO THE JAM with shaking hands because the next float of shapes is already coming and the gun is the only thing on this ridge that matters more than any of them, and everyone in the pit knows it, including the gun.

The round comes free. The bolt slams home.

RAY (CONT'D)  
(a whisper; thanks or  
prayer, no difference  
left)

There.

And the gun speaks again, and the muzzle light strobes his face, and we hold on it -- nineteen, burned, blank, lit in flashes -- the unsmiling boy from the hallway photograph being manufactured in front of us, one flash at a time --

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

**INT. KOVACH HOUSE -- SPARE ROOM -- THE NEXT MORNING**

Wyatt asleep in the recliner -- the recliner that faces the door -- papers on his chest, phone dead on the floor. He slept here. He didn't decide to; the room decided.

Morning light through the one window. He wakes, and for a second doesn't know the year. Then does. Sits up.

On the workbench, where he left it: the letter. "It is not that I don't"

**INT. KOVACH HOUSE -- KITCHEN -- MORNING**

Denise, back with coffee and the empty Ferguson dish, going through mail. Wyatt enters holding one thing: the photograph of six.

WYATT  
Ma. When you were a kid. Fourth  
of July.

DENISE  
(not looking up)  
What about it.

WYATT  
Did Grandpa come?

DENISE

(a pause; the mail  
slowing)

He'd come to the barbecue part.

(beat)

He'd leave before dark. Every  
year. Said the smoke bothered his  
eyes.

(beat; the mail stopped  
now; a thing she has  
never once assembled  
out loud before this  
moment, assembling)

And one year -- I was maybe ten  
-- the Pettits set off a whole  
brick of firecrackers next door  
with no warning, middle of the  
afternoon, and I couldn't find  
him after, and Mom said go play,  
and --

(she looks up at Wyatt)

He was in the garage. Standing at  
the bench with all the tools. Not  
fixing anything. Just standing  
there holding the edge of it. And  
Mom stood in the door and  
wouldn't let anybody in the  
garage till dinner.

(beat)

She never explained it. I never  
asked. You just -- it was Dad.  
Dad was quiet.

Wyatt sets the photograph down on the mail, facing her.  
Six boys. Five crosses.

WYATT

That's him. Second row of that  
quiet.

Denise looks at the photo for a long time. Picks it up.  
Puts her reading glasses on to see it, which somehow makes  
it worse.

DENISE

(quietly)

He's a baby.

(beat)

Which one is he?

WYATT

The one not laughing.

She finds him. Her thumb hovers over the face the way Wyatt's hovered over the dog tags -- family gestures, inherited like eye color.

DENISE  
(setting it down; brisk  
again, but two degrees  
off true now)  
The dumpster still comes  
Thursday, Wyatt.

WYATT  
I know.

DENISE  
(from the door; not  
turning around; the  
closest she comes in  
this film)  
Nothing of his goes in it.

**INT. KOVACH HOUSE -- SPARE ROOM -- DAY**

Wyatt at the workbench, the letter flat in front of him. Beside it, his phone -- 43 comments, un-answered text, all of it -- set face down. Deliberate. A choice being practiced.

He reads the letter's two dead starts again. Then turns it over.

ON THE BACK -- and he has to angle it to the window to see it, pencil gone silver with age -- there is more. Not a letter. A list. No date. No salutation. Just Ray's small even print, one entry at a time, written -- by the changing pencil pressure -- over many different days:

INSERT -- THE LIST:

"Pyne. After. Trenton NJ. Roofing."

"Russo. After. Bricklayer. Died 61. Heart."

"Crumpton. Went back to Ozark AL. Wrote me 3 letters. I answered 1. Should have answered 3."

"Beck. On the ridge."

"Ostrowski. On the ridge. I have his glasses. Wrote his mother 1946. Could not mail it. Wrote again 1952. Could not mail it."

"The Gunny. Iwo. Feb 45. First day."

And at the bottom of the list, alone, the last entry, the pencil pressed so hard it tore the fiber:

"Everybody carried something home. Nobody helped anybody carry it. That was the mistake. Not the ridge. The after."

Wyatt sits with that. The AC hums. And this time, the cut, when it comes, is different -- not triggered by touching an object. He closes his eyes and GOES there, on purpose, the first voluntary crossing --

**EXT. THE RIDGE -- DAWN -- OCTOBER 25, 1942**

Gray light. The fog burning off the low ground in rags.

And SILENCE. Enormous, wrong, ringing silence -- the loudest sound cut in the film, after twelve hours of the other thing.

The gun's barrel ticks as it cools. The slope below the wire is what it is; the camera stays in the pit and lets the men's faces do the reporting.

Ray sits behind the gun. Not slumped -- seated, upright, hands in his lap palm-up because they can't close. Crumpton beside him, head wrapped, staring at the belt can with the dent in it. Down the line, one by one, the survivors' heads rising out of holes into the gray light like men surfacing.

A RUNNER comes down the line, crouched from habit though nothing is firing.

RUNNER  
(hoarse; to each hole)  
Count. Sections. Count.

PYNE (O.S.)  
(a long pause; then,  
from his hole, the  
arithmetic of the rest  
of Ray's life)  
...Three. Sections got three up.

The runner moves on. Three. Ray hears the number land on him. He looks down the line: himself. Crumpton. Russo, standing in his pit with his helmet in his hands like a man who's forgotten what it's for.

And Basilone -- moving up the line in the gray light, checking holes, doing inventory, same as dusk, a man whose night we now know and who looks, mostly, like he needs a cigarette and a wall to lean on. He passes Ray's pit. Puts

his hand once more, flat, on the receiver of the gun. It's cool now. He nods at it -- at the gun, at Ray, no boundary between them anymore.

BASILONE  
 (quietly; moving on;  
 the last thing he ever  
 says to Ray)  
 Steel.

Ray watches him go. And now, only now, Ray looks at his own hands, palm-up in his lap, burned in the shape of a barrel. He does not feel triumphant. We watch him look down the smoking slope at what held, and we watch him understand that the boy who dug this hole yesterday at dusk is on the ridge with Beck and Ostrowski, and that whoever stands up out of this pit and walks down to the beach and boards the ship and comes home to Johnstown and marries Eleanor and fixes things for fifty years --

-- is going to be somebody else, wearing his tags.

RAY  
 (to no one; to the  
 silence; almost  
 inaudible)  
 All right.

He picks the broken glasses up out of the mud beside the gun -- Ostrowski's -- wipes them, one-handed, on the cleanest part of his sleeve. Puts them in his breast pocket. Buttons it.

HARD CUT:

**INT. KOVACH HOUSE -- SPARE ROOM -- DAY**

Wyatt's eyes open. He is holding the glasses. His thumb is on the button of his own shirt pocket, without him knowing.

He puts them down, gently, on the workbench, in the little shadow-board outline meant for a wrench. They fit fine. Everything fits somewhere, in this room.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

**INT. KOVACH HOUSE -- SPARE ROOM -- DUSK**

The window going gold, then gray. Wyatt hasn't turned the light on. He sits on the floor with the letter in its

sleeve, reading the two dead starts for the twentieth time -- and the twentieth time is the one where he finally reads them right. Not as failure. As attempts.

WYATT  
(quietly; to the  
letter)  
You tried twice.

And on the word "twice," the room cuts out -- but softer this time, the film's grammar evolving, because this crossing isn't the ridge. It's what the letter couldn't say:

**INT. KOVACH HOUSE -- BEDROOM -- NIGHT -- 1954 [THE LETTER'S WORLD]**

The same house. Younger walls. A double bed in moonlight.

RAY, 31 now, the boy's face gone to the man's, asleep -- and then not asleep. Rigid. Eyes open at the ceiling. Hands flat at his sides on top of the covers, palm-down, pressing, the way you press on something to make sure it's real and room temperature.

Beside him, ELEANOR, 28, awake too. We understand from her stillness that this is not the first night. She does not touch him -- she has learned, we understand, that touching is wrong during this. Instead:

ELEANOR  
(quietly; to the  
ceiling;  
conversational)  
The Hendersons are putting in a  
carport. Poured the slab today.  
It's crooked.

Nothing. Ray, rigid, at the ceiling.

ELEANOR (CONT'D)  
(same tone; unhurried;  
a woman laying planks  
across a hole one at a  
time)  
Half an inch over four feet. You  
can see it from the kitchen.  
It'll pond every time it rains  
and he'll blame the concrete man.

A long moment. Then Ray's breathing changes. Slows. His hands unpress.



RAY  
(hoarse; at the  
ceiling; coming back)  
...Half an inch over four feet.

ELEANOR  
Mm.

RAY  
(beat)  
That'll pond.

ELEANOR  
That's what I said.

Silence. The moonlight. Two people staring at a ceiling,  
holding a line nobody will ever give either of them a  
citation for.

RAY  
(very quietly; the  
closest he will come in  
fifty years)  
Ellie. There was a night --

ELEANOR  
(instantly; gently;  
both hands on the  
moment)  
I know.

RAY  
You don't --

ELEANOR  
No. I don't.  
(beat)  
And you don't have to make me,  
Raymond. That's not the price of  
anything. There's no price.  
You're home.

Hold on Ray's face in the moonlight -- and we watch him  
take the sentence that was halfway up his throat and  
swallow it, and we understand, with terrible clarity, that  
this moment of mercy is also the moment the letter dies --  
that her kindness and his silence will now hold each other  
up for fifty years, like two walls with no house between  
them.

RAY  
 (finally)  
 The Hendersons overpaid for that  
 slab.

ELEANOR  
 (settling into her  
 pillow; the night  
 survived)  
 Wildly.

**INT. KOVACH HOUSE -- SPARE ROOM -- NIGHT [PRESENT]**

Full dark now. Wyatt on the floor, the letter in his hands.

WYATT  
 (to the room; to both  
 of them; to the house  
 that heard all of it  
 and kept it)  
 She kept the key, though.  
 (beat; working it out;  
 the whole film's  
 arithmetic done aloud,  
 once, quietly)  
 She couldn't get you to open it.  
 So she made sure somebody could.

He looks at the padlock key on its wire loop. The tag in her handwriting. "NO."

Not Ray's no. Hers. A quote. A wife filing her husband's answer, all those years, under the one word he kept giving her -- and keeping the key anyway, oiled, findable, waiting for a grandson with a Thursday deadline and three piles.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

**INT. WAREHOUSE -- FULFILLMENT CENTER -- VISALIA -- DAY  
 [DAYS LATER]**

Fluorescent forever. Conveyor hum. Wyatt back at work, in a safety vest, scanning totes with a handheld gun -- BEEP -- shelving -- BEEP -- the gig-adjacent nothing of it, the film making no comment, because Wyatt is specific, not a generation.

At break, in the fenced smoking area he doesn't smoke in, coworkers around a phone, laughing at something. One of

them -- KAYLEN, 22, decent, oblivious -- waves him over.

KAYLEN

Wyatt. Wyatt. You gotta see this,  
they're absolutely ending this  
dude in the comments --

Wyatt looks at the phone. Some stranger. Some pile-on. Forty-three comments times ten thousand, the whole weather system of it, the thing that put a hole in him weeks ago, playing now as entertainment on a break-room phone.

And we watch him almost say nothing -- the numb reflex, the keep-your-head-down -- and then:

WYATT

(handing the phone  
back; even; no speech  
in it)

Nah. I know how that feels from  
the other end. It's not that  
funny over there.

Beat. Kaylen blinks.

KAYLEN

...It's kind of funny.

WYATT

(going back to his  
totes; not unkind;  
done)

Everything's kind of funny.

That's the whole beat. Nobody's mind is changed. Nobody claps. Kaylen watches him go, shrugs, scrolls on. But Wyatt walks back to the line with his shoulders one degree different, and the scanner goes BEEP, and that's the size of victories in this movie.

#### **INT. WYATT'S APARTMENT -- NIGHT**

Small. A mattress and frame that don't match. A gaming chair worth more than the rest of the furniture. On the desk, in the lamplight: the dog tags, the photo of six, and the letter, in a document sleeve now -- he bought a document sleeve; we see the drugstore bag.

Wyatt at the desk, phone in hand. He opens the group chat -- the one that went nuclear, the one he's been carrying like a wound. Scrolls it one last time. The pile-on, the screenshots, the forty-three comments. His thumb hovers over the text box, over the paragraph he has clearly

drafted in his head for weeks, the defense, the counter-thread, the case.

He looks at the letter on the desk. "It is not that I don't"

He closes the text box. Doesn't post. Doesn't delete the app either -- no gestures. He just mutes the thread, sets the phone face down, and it's the same motion his grandfather's thumb made buttoning a breast pocket in 1942, and the film does not point this out.

He picks up the dog tags instead. Works one tag off the chain -- the duplicate; the military issues two -- and threads it onto his own keyring, between the apartment key and the warehouse fob. It looks wrong there. It looks right there. Both.

Then he pulls the laptop over and opens a chat window. A cursor, blinking, in a text field. The soft dark of the room. 2:04 AM.

He types. Hunt-and-peck, like a search bar, like his grandfather's pencil, one true line at a time:

INSERT -- SCREEN, the words appearing letter by letter:

"my grandpa was at guadalcana. he was one of 3 guys left out of his machine gun sections after henderson field. basilone got the medal of honor, he got 70 years of not talking. i found the whole thing in a footlocker tuesday. my grandma kept it locked her whole life and kept the key labeled NO and kept it anyway."

He stops. Reads it. Keeps going:

"i got wrecked by a group chat 6 weeks ago. 43 comments. i haven't slept right since. i'm not saying it's the same thing. i know it's not the same thing. he held a ridge and i couldn't hold a comment section."

He stops again. Deletes nothing. Types the last of it:

"i just think he had a guy next to him in the hole and i have this. and i wanted to say it to something once, out loud, before i put it all back in the box. he wrote 2 letters he couldn't finish and a list of everybody he didn't help carry it. i don't want a list like that. that's it. that's the whole thing."

His finger rests on the enter key. A long moment -- the film's whole argument balanced on a keystroke -- and he presses it.

The reply comes fast. Too fast. It always comes too fast.

INSERT -- SCREEN, the response, instant, fluent, formatted:

"That sounds incredibly meaningful. It's understandable to feel a complex mix of emotions when discovering family history. Would you like some tips for preserving and archiving historical military documents?"

Hold on the screen. Flat. Small. Almost inadequate. The cursor blinks under it, patient, the way only things with nothing at stake can be patient.

Wyatt reads it. And -- quietly, to himself, in the lamplight -- he does something we have not seen him do in the entire film:

He laughs. Once. Small. Real.

WYATT  
(to the screen; without  
bitterness; the sound  
of a debt being  
accepted)  
Yeah. No. This one's mine.

He closes the laptop. The room goes dark except the window's streetlight. He sits there in it, unhurried, a man alone in a hole holding what he's holding -- and okay. Actually okay. Or close enough to start.

**INT. KOVACH HOUSE -- SPARE ROOM -- DAY [DAYS LATER]**

The house nearly empty now. Echoes where furniture was. Denise's three piles gone to their three fates.

Wyatt, alone, closes the footlocker. The papers inside it now in sleeves, in order -- not archived like a museum; squared away like a kit. He clicks the padlock shut and puts the key -- the key labeled NO in Eleanor's faded pencil -- into his shirt pocket. Buttons it.

He lifts the footlocker by one handle. It's heavy. It was always going to be heavy.

DENISE (O.S.)  
(from the hall, passing  
with a box)  
You taking that?

WYATT  
Yeah.

DENISE (O.S.)

What even is it?

A beat. The door of the empty room. The bleached light.  
His grandfather's quiet, banked in him now like coals.

WYATT

Tools.

He carries it out. The room stands empty -- bed gone,  
bench gone, just the pegboard on the wall, every painted  
outline holding its shape with nothing in it, the way this  
family holds things.

Except one outline. Where a wrench should be: OSTROWSKI'S  
GLASSES, resting in the painted silhouette, left on  
purpose, fitting fine.

The light through the window moves a quarter-inch, the way  
light does when a film is ending.

**EXT. KOVACH HOUSE -- DAY**

Wyatt loads the footlocker into the bed of a borrowed  
truck. Slams the gate. Stands a second in the driveway of  
a house that has now officially stopped being anyone's.

His phone buzzes in his pocket. He takes it out. Looks at  
it.

Puts it back. Not a gesture. Just an order of operations.

He gets in the truck. On his keyring, swinging from the  
ignition as the engine turns over: an apartment key, a  
warehouse fob, and a dog tag, stamped KOVACH R J, catching  
the Central Valley sun once, hard, like a muzzle flash --

-- and then it's just a keyring again.

He pulls out. The truck goes down the ordinary street,  
past the ordinary houses, full of three generations of  
unremarkable lives, all of it paid for on a ridge in the  
dark by a nineteen-year-old with burned hands, and none of  
it knowing, which was the point.

Which was always the entire point.

FADE OUT.

THE END